

Game Design Document (GDD)

Game Summary

"Dusha" is a dark-fantasy action RPG set in a mysterious Underworld where lost souls, known as Dusha, seek to reclaim their memories. Players take on the role of a Dusha who awakens in a ruined city and soon learns that the only way to remember their past is to defeat the seven Special Guards, each embodying one of the Seven Deadly Sins. As players progress, they uncover a deep narrative about life, death, and judgment, all while battling monstrous creatures and formidable foes.

1. Theme

The game explores themes of memory, fate, and redemption. The world is gothic and eerie, featuring a blend of decayed ruins, ominous palaces, and supernatural landscapes. Character designs reflect an ethereal, spectral quality, and enemies have grotesque, otherworldly appearances. The environment storytelling is deeply inspired by classic mythology and existential horror.

2. Genre

- Action RPG
- Dark Fantasy
- Soulslike
- Narrative-driven Adventure

3. Target Audience

- Age Group: 16+ year
- Interests: Fans of challenging combat, dark storytelling, and mythological themes.
- We noticed that age group of 16+ like to play dark and brutal games like NineSols, Library of Ruina



4. Platform

- Primary: PC,

5. Influences

- **Dark Souls** – The combat system will heavily emphasize precise timing for both player attacks and defensive maneuvers. Success in combat will hinge on understanding enemy attack patterns and executing well-timed dodges, parries (if applicable), and attacks.

• Specific Implementation:

- **Attack Timing:** Player attacks will have distinct wind-up and recovery animations, requiring deliberate input rather than button-mashing. Different attack types (e.g., light, heavy) may have varying speeds and damage.
- **Dodge/Roll:** A core defensive mechanic allowing the player to evade enemy attacks with a brief window of invulnerability. The timing and positioning of the dodge will be crucial.
- **Hollow Knight** – The game world will be a vast, interconnected 2D environment that encourages exploration and discovery. Atmosphere and a sense of mystery will be paramount.

Specific Implementation: Interconnected Map: Levels will be designed with branching paths, hidden areas, and shortcuts that unlock as the player progresses. A detailed in-game map will be essential for navigation.

Atmospheric Visuals & Sound: A distinct visual style and evocative sound design (music and sound effects) will be used to create a strong sense of atmosphere and immerse the player in the world.

Secrets & Rewards: Exploration will be rewarded with valuable items, upgrades, lore fragments, and hidden challenges, encouraging players to venture off the beaten path.

- **Blasphemous** -The game will adopt a dark and gothic aesthetic, characterized by detailed, imposing architecture, and a sense of oppressive atmosphere. Failure will carry significant consequences, reinforcing the importance of focused play.

Specific Implementation:

- **Visual Style:** A distinct gothic art style with detailed character and environment designs, potentially featuring religious or macabre themes. A muted color palette with contrasting highlights can enhance the atmosphere.

Challenging Difficulty: Enemy encounters will be designed to be challenging, demanding skillful execution and strategic thinking. Enemy placement and combinations will require careful consideration.

6. Camera

The game uses a simple Cinemachine camera to track and show characters movements and actions by players to the player in 2D perspective. There will not be much camera shaking effects throughout the game unless the player is going against the 7 main bosses.

Gameplay

a. Objective

Defeating the Seven Deadly Sins: These encounters will serve as major milestones in the game, likely representing significant challenges in terms of combat and strategy. The order in which players confront these sins might be fixed or offer some degree of choice, impacting progression and potentially the narrative revealed.

Memory Recovery: Each Sin defeated will trigger a narrative sequence where the player character regains pieces of their lost memories. These could be presented through cutscenes, interactive flashbacks, or environmental storytelling elements triggered by the boss's defeat.

Uncovering the Truth: The recovered memories will collectively contribute to a larger narrative that the player must piece together. The ultimate goal is to understand the protagonist's past, the nature of the Sins, and their connection to them.

b. Game Pillars

1. Challenging Combat

Description: The combat system will be designed to be methodical and skill-based, demanding precision, timing, and strategic thinking. Success will not come from rapid button presses but from understanding enemy behavior, utilizing the player's abilities effectively, and making deliberate choices in the heat of battle.

Specific Implementation

Deliberate Actions: Player actions (attacks, dodges, special abilities) will have clear start-up and recovery frames, requiring thoughtful execution.

- **Enemy Telegraphing:** Enemies will exhibit distinct visual and auditory cues before executing attacks, providing players with opportunities to react and counter.
- **Meaningful Enemy Variety:** Different enemy types will possess unique attack patterns, behaviors, and weaknesses, requiring players to adapt their strategies for each encounter.
- **Emphasis on Positioning:** The 2D plane will be utilized strategically, with enemy placement and player positioning being crucial for avoiding attacks and maximizing offensive opportunities.
- **Potential for Defensive Mechanics:** Beyond dodging, consider implementing parrying, blocking, or other defensive options that require skillful timing.

2. Memory Recovery System

Description: The act of defeating the Seven Deadly Sins will be directly linked to the protagonist's journey of regaining their lost memories. Each victory will unlock fragments of their past, gradually revealing the overarching narrative.

Specific Implementation:

- **Post-Boss Narrative Sequences:** Upon defeating a Sin, players will experience a memory recovery sequence. This could be a cinematic cutscene, an interactive flashback where the player controls the past self, or a series of environmental changes that reveal past events.
- **Fragmented Information:** The recovered memories will likely be non-linear and fragmented initially, requiring players to piece together the full picture as they progress. This can create intrigue and encourage them to defeat all the Sins.
- **Lore Integration:** The memories recovered can also serve to reveal more about the game's world, its history, and the nature of the Seven Deadly Sins, enriching the "Atmospheric World-Building" pillar.
- **Potential for Optional Memories:** Consider incorporating hidden areas or challenges that unlock additional, optional memory fragments, rewarding thorough exploration.

3. Atmospheric World-Building

Description: The game world will be a non-linear environment rich in atmosphere and lore. The story will be conveyed not just through direct exposition but also through the details of the environments, item descriptions, and subtle visual cues. Exploration will be key to uncovering the world's secrets and history.

Specific Implementation

Detailed Environments: Each location will have a distinct visual identity and be filled with details that hint at past events, the nature of its inhabitants (if any), and the overall lore of the world.

Environmental Storytelling: Pay attention to architecture, decaying structures, remnants of past civilizations, and the placement of objects to tell stories without explicit dialogue.

Item Descriptions & Lore Texts: Item descriptions, collectible notes, or environmental inscriptions can provide valuable insights into the game's lore and history.

4. Morality & Judgment System

Description: The choices players make throughout the game will have tangible effects on how the story unfolds and potentially influence the final outcome. The "judgment" upon death, offering a choice between losing progress and making a sacrifice, is a prime example of this system in action.

Dialogue Choices (If Applicable): If the game features dialogue with NPCs, choices made in conversations could impact relationships, unlock different quests, or alter future events.

Subtle Influences: Some choices might have less obvious but still significant impacts on the world or the protagonist's understanding of their past.

World Design & Environments

The world of "Dusha" is a haunting and oppressive Underworld, a realm where the remnants of forgotten lives coalesce into eerie landscapes. It is a place that feels both ancient and eternally decaying, reflecting the lost memories and unresolved fates of the souls trapped within. The environment itself serves as a constant reminder of mortality, judgment, and the elusive nature of the past.

Underworld Setting and Atmosphere

- **Description:** The game world is a multifaceted Underworld, not a traditional hellscape, but a more nuanced realm that exists in the liminal space between

life and true oblivion. It is characterized by a pervasive sense of loss, mystery, and the weight of forgotten experiences. The atmosphere will be thick with a gothic eeriness, blending decaying grandeur with supernatural elements.

- **Specific Regions/Biomes:**

- **The Ruined City (Starting Area):**

- **Visuals:** Crumbling gothic architecture, overgrown with strange, ethereal flora. Streets are choked with dust and the remnants of a lost civilization. Flickering spectral lights provide the only illumination in shadowed alleys. Broken statues and faded murals hint at a once grand society.
 - **Atmosphere:** A sense of immediate desolation and abandonment. Whispers of past inhabitants might be heard on the wind. The environment feels heavy with unspoken stories.
 - **Gameplay:** Serves as an introduction to the game's mechanics and atmosphere. May contain early enemies and clues about the player's initial amnesia.

Supernatural Landscapes:

- **Visuals:** Regions that defy natural laws, such as floating islands connected by ethereal bridges, forests with luminescent and twisted trees, or landscapes where the very ground seems to writhe and shift. These areas might be more abstract and dreamlike, reflecting the fragmented and unreliable nature of memory.
- **Atmosphere:** A sense of the otherworldly and the surreal. These environments can evoke both wonder and unease, blurring the lines between dream and nightmare.
- **Gameplay:** May contain unique environmental hazards, challenging platforming sections, and hidden areas containing valuable lore or items.



Mechanics

Core Mechanics

Grappling (Spectral Chain)

Description: The Dusha possesses a spectral chain, an ethereal tether that can be projected and latched onto specific anchor points within the environment, enemies, and even certain projectiles. This versatile ability forms a core part of both exploration and combat, offering dynamic movement options and tactical advantages.

The Spectral Chain allows the Dusha to overcome vertical obstacles and horizontal gaps that would otherwise be impassable. Anchor points, visually distinct ethereal nodes or specific environmental features, will be strategically placed to encourage exploration of less obvious paths and hidden areas.

Specific Implementation:

- **Swinging:** Latching onto an overhead anchor point allows the Dusha to swing across large chasms. Momentum and timing will be key to successful swings.
- **Pulling Towards:** Latching onto distant platforms or ledges allows the Dusha to pull themselves towards them.

Meta Core Mechanic

Shapeshifting

Description: The Dusha possesses the unique ability to manifest different spectral forms, each reflecting a facet of their fragmented past self. These transformations are not merely cosmetic; they grant distinct abilities and alter the Dusha's capabilities in both exploration and, crucially, combat. Players can fluidly switch between these forms mid-action, allowing for highly adaptive and strategic gameplay.

Detailed Abilities:

- **Enhanced Evasion:** Significantly increases the Dusha's dodge distance, reduces the recovery time after dodging, and potentially grants a higher number of consecutive dodges.
- **Increased Movement Speed:** Allows for faster traversal of environments, quicker repositioning in combat, and the ability to outmaneuver faster enemies.
- **Spectral Passage:** Enables the Dusha to briefly phase through specific types of thin walls, ethereal barriers, or grates, opening up hidden pathways or allowing for tactical escapes. This might have a limited duration or a cooldown.

Teleportation

Description: The Dusha will gain the ability to teleport between specific locations within the Underworld that they have previously discovered and unlocked. This mechanic serves multiple crucial functions, including efficient traversal, providing safe havens, facilitating player progression, and enabling access to essential services.

Specific Implementation:

- **Teleportation Points:** These will be specific locations within the game world, visually distinct and often located near significant landmarks, safe areas, or the entrances/exits of major regions. They could be ancient, spectral gateways, or remnants of forgotten technology.

- **Unlocking:** Teleportation points will need to be discovered and "activated" by the player. This could involve a simple interaction, solving a minor puzzle, or defeating a local challenge.
- **Teleportation Interface:** Players will likely access a map or a dedicated menu that displays all currently unlocked teleportation points, allowing them to select their destination.

Game Flow

Awakening in the Ruined City:

- **Expanded Description:** The game begins with the Dusha awakening in the desolate remnants of a once-grand city. They are amnesiac, with no recollection of their past. This initial area serves as a tutorial, introducing basic movement, combat mechanics, and the core concept of the Spectral Chain for traversal. The atmosphere will immediately establish the haunting yet captivating nature of the Underworld.
- **Potential Gameplay Beats:**
 - Limited movement and basic attack tutorials.
 - Introduction to the Spectral Chain for simple platforming and object interaction.
 - Encountering weak initial enemies to learn basic combat timing and evasion.
 - Discovering cryptic environmental storytelling elements hinting at the city's fate.
 - A sense of isolation and mystery as the player begins to question their surroundings and identity.

Discovering the Dusha Hideout:

- **Expanded Description:** Through exploration of the ruined city, the player will stumble upon a hidden sanctuary or hideout inhabited by other lost souls (Dusha). This location will serve as a central hub for the player. Here, they might encounter non-playable characters (NPCs) who provide information about the Underworld, the Seven Deadly Sins, and potentially offer guidance or services (e.g., early forms of shops or lore dumps).
- **Potential Gameplay Beats:**
 - Encountering the first friendly NPCs who explain the nature of the Dusha and the goal of reclaiming memories.
 - Introduction to the game's lore and the significance of the Seven Deadly Sins.
 - Unlocking the first basic shop or upgrade option.
 - Receiving initial quests or directions on how to begin hunting the Sins.
 - Potentially learning more about the player character's unique abilities, like Shapeshifting, through interactions or environmental discoveries within the hideout.

Hunting the Seven Deadly Sins:

- **Expanded Description:** This forms the main bulk of the game. The player will embark on a journey to locate and confront each of the Seven Deadly Sins, powerful entities residing in distinct regions of the Underworld. Each Sin will embody a specific aspect of their namesake, reflected in their personality, the environment of their domain, and their combat style. The order in which players can hunt the Sins might be linear or offer some degree of choice.
- **Potential Gameplay Beats (Per Sin):**
 - Exploration of a new, thematically distinct region influenced by the specific Sin (e.g., a lavish but decaying palace for Greed, a fiery and chaotic domain for Wrath).
 - Encountering unique enemies that serve as minions or manifestations of the Sin.
 - Solving environmental puzzles or overcoming challenges related to the Sin's nature.
 - Learning about the Sin's backstory and their connection to the Underworld through environmental storytelling and potentially encounters with other Dusha.
 - A climactic boss battle against the Sin, requiring mastery of the Dusha's abilities and strategic thinking.

Unlocking Memory Fragments:

- **Expanded Description:** Upon defeating each of the Seven Deadly Sins, the player will recover fragmented memories of their past life. These memories will be presented through various means, such as cutscenes, interactive flashbacks, or changes in the environment. Each recovered fragment will offer a piece of the puzzle surrounding the Dusha's identity, their life before death, and the reasons for their current predicament.
- **Potential Gameplay Beats:**
 - Triggering a memory sequence immediately after defeating a Sin.
 - Collecting memory fragments scattered within the Sin's domain.
 - Returning to the Dusha hideout to share or reflect on the recovered memories, potentially leading to new insights or quests.
 - The narrative gradually unfolds, revealing more about the protagonist's past and their connection to the Seven Deadly Sins.

Facing the Final Judgment:

- **Expanded Description:** After defeating all Seven Deadly Sins and piecing together a significant portion of their lost memories, the player will confront the ultimate consequence of their past actions – the Final Judgment. This could involve a final, challenging encounter with a powerful entity or a series of moral choices based on the truths revealed through the recovered memories. The outcome of this judgment will determine Dusha's fate and the game's ending.
- **Potential Gameplay Beats:**
 - Unlocking a final area or series of challenges leading to the Final Judgment.

- Confronting a powerful antagonist or a manifestation of the Underworld's judgment system.
- Making significant choices based on the player's understanding of their past and the nature of the Sins.
- Multiple potential endings depending on the player's actions and choices throughout the game.
- A concluding narrative sequence that resolves the Dusha's story and the mysteries of the Underworld.

Game Economy

Currency System

- "Dusha" features a dual currency system consisting of a "Soft Currency," primarily obtained from regular enemy encounters, and a rarer "Hard Currency," primarily rewarded for defeating significant challenges like boss fights. This distinction aims to create a sense of value for overcoming difficult obstacles and provides a tiered system for purchasing upgrades and essential items.

Acquisition:

- Defeating Regular Enemies: The primary source of soft currency will be defeating standard enemies encountered throughout the Underworld. The amount earned may vary depending on the enemy type, their difficulty, and potentially the player's current level or equipment.
- Environmental Discoveries: Small amounts of soft currency could be found hidden within the environment, rewarding thorough exploration. This could be in destructible objects, hidden caches, or as rewards for minor environmental puzzles.

Uses:

- Minor Upgrades: Purchasing small enhancements to the Dusha's base stats (e.g., slight increase to health, stamina regeneration), or minor improvements to the Spectral Chain's range or speed.
- Consumables: Buying items that provide temporary buffs (e.g., increased attack power, temporary defense boost), restore health or energy, or offer other temporary advantages.
- Basic Equipment: Purchasing entry-level gear or minor enhancements to existing equipment.
- Repair Costs (If Applicable): If equipment degrades over time, soft currency could be used for repairs.

Hard Currency:

Acquisition:

- **Defeating Boss Fights (Seven Deadly Sins):** The primary and most significant source of hard currency will be the successful defeat of each of the Seven Deadly Sins. Each Sin could reward a substantial amount of hard currency or a unique token that can be exchanged for it.

- **Completing Major Quests:** Significant story-related quests or challenging side quests might reward the player with hard currency.
- **Hidden and Difficult Challenges:** Secret areas or particularly difficult optional encounters could offer hard currency as a rare and valuable reward for skilled players.
- **Major Skill Unlocks (Shapeshifting, Spectral Chain):** Hard currency will be required to unlock new spectral forms, significant upgrades for the Spectral Chain (e.g., Tethering, Chain Lash), and other powerful abilities.
- **Memory Recovery:** A portion of the hard currency earned from defeating a Sin might be directly tied to unlocking the associated memory fragment, emphasizing the connection between overcoming the Sin and regaining the past. Alternatively, players might need to spend hard currency at a specific location or with an NPC to fully access and understand the recovered memories.

Balancing Considerations:

- **Pacing of Acquisition:** The rate at which players earn both soft and hard currency needs to be carefully balanced to ensure a satisfying sense of progression without feeling too grindy or too easy.
- **Value of Purchases:** The cost of items and upgrades should feel appropriate for the effort required to earn the currency. Major upgrades requiring hard currency should offer a noticeable and impactful benefit.
- **Hard Currency Significance:** Hard currency should feel truly valuable and its acquisition tied to significant accomplishments, reinforcing the importance of overcoming major challenges